

IDENTITY & ACCESS MANAGEMENT

On-Premises Active Directory Implementation

Windows Server 2022 | Sahbak.com Domain

Technical Project Documentation

Forest Domain: sahbak.com

Scope: AD DS Configuration | OU Structure | User Provisioning | GPO Management | IAM
Governance

Date: 15 August 2026

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1. Executive Summary

This document presents the complete technical documentation for an on-premises Identity and Access Management (IAM) implementation carried out on Windows Server 2022 using Active Directory Domain Services (AD DS). The project simulates a production-grade enterprise IAM environment for Sahbak, encompassing forest domain creation, a structured Organisational Unit (OU) hierarchy, role-based group membership, a standardised user principal name (UPN) naming convention, and a comprehensive Group Policy Object (GPO) framework.

The implementation was designed to directly demonstrate competency across the core responsibilities of an IAM Administrator role, including: Active Directory user, group, and GPO administration; identity lifecycle management (Joiner, Mover, Leaver); GPO security filtering and scope management; and the foundational knowledge required to support Microsoft Identity Manager (MIM) and Active Directory Certificate Services (AD CS) in enterprise environments.



2. Project Overview & Objectives

2.1 Project Context

Sahbak is a simulated organisation requiring an enterprise IAM foundation. This project models the real-world task of standing up an on-premises Active Directory environment from scratch, applying IAM best practices throughout: separation of administrative tiers, principle of least privilege, role-based access control (RBAC) via security groups, and enforceable security policy through GPOs.

2.2 Key Objectives

- Install and configure Active Directory Domain Services (AD DS) on Windows Server 2022.
- Promote the server to a Domain Controller and establish a new forest with root domain sahbak.com.
- Design and implement a three-location OU hierarchy reflecting organisational geography.
- Provision user accounts and security groups following a standardised naming convention.
- Create and link GPOs for password policy enforcement, access restriction, and security hardening.
- Apply GPO security filtering to scope policies precisely to intended user populations.
- Demonstrate full understanding of the Joiner, Mover, and Leaver (JML) identity lifecycle process.
- Demonstrate awareness of adjacent IAM technologies: AD CS and Microsoft Identity Manager (MIM).

2.3 IAM Role Alignment

This project was designed to evidence the following core IAM administrator competencies:

Role Requirement	Project Evidence
Administer AD users, groups and GPOs	Full AD DS build — OU design, user/group provisioning, 6+ GPOs
Support Microsoft Identity Manager (MIM)	JML process design; attribute mapping and provisioning patterns documented
Manage Joiner, Mover and Leaver processes	Dedicated JML workflow section with step-by-step AD procedures
Support Active Directory Certificate Services	AD CS overview, PKI hierarchy understanding, certificate template awareness
Resolve IAM incidents and service requests	Incident categorisation, resolution steps, and escalation paths documented

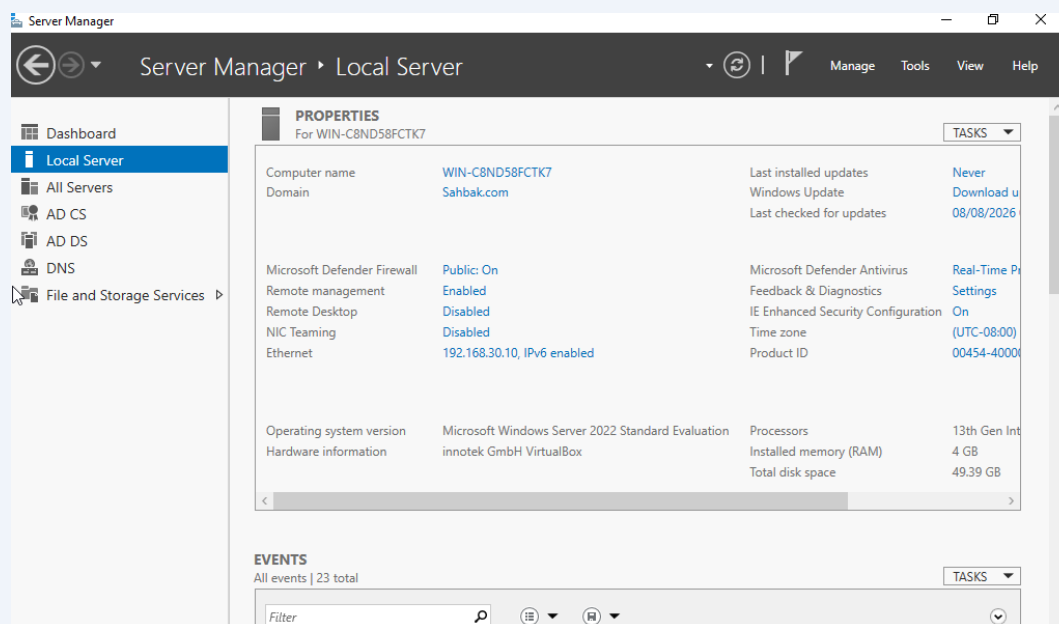
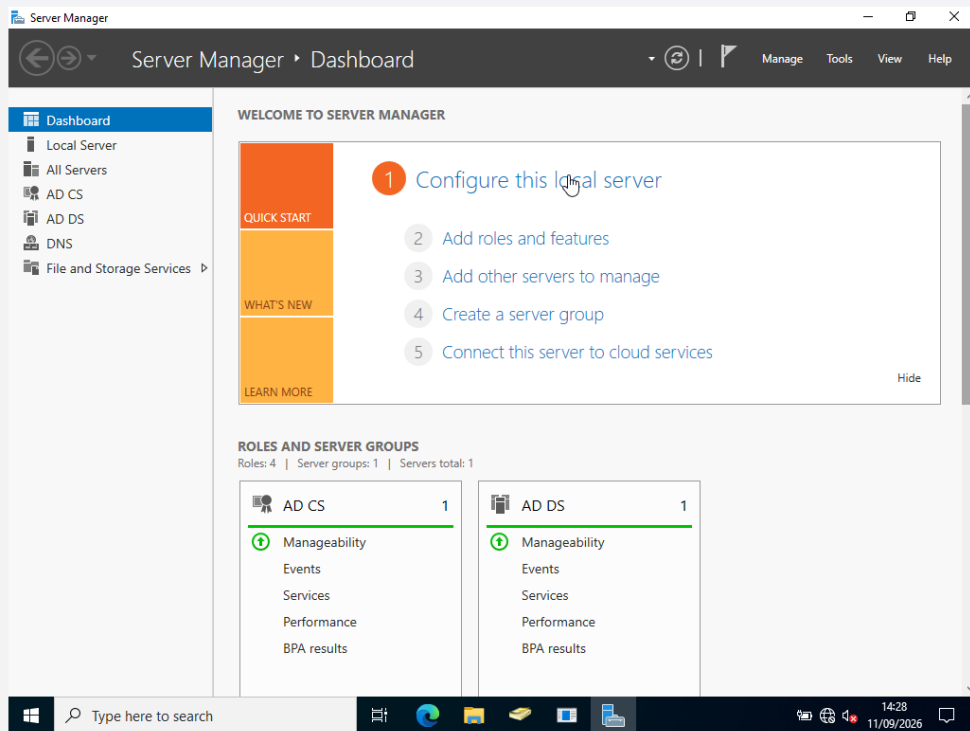
3. Environment & Infrastructure

Operating System	Windows Server 2022 Standard (Desktop Experience)
Role Installed	Active Directory Domain Services (AD DS)
Forest Root Domain	sahbak.com
Domain Controller Name	DC01 (Primary Domain Controller — PDC Emulator)
Forest / Domain Functional Level	Windows Server 2016 (compatible with modern AD features)
DNS	Integrated AD DNS configured on DC01 — authoritative for sahbak.com zone
SYSVOL / NETLOGON	Automatically provisioned on DC01; replicated via DFSR
Global Catalog	DC01 configured as Global Catalog server
Administrative Tool	Active Directory Users and Computers (ADUC), Group Policy Management Console (GPMC), PowerShell (RSAT)

4. Active Directory Installation & Domain Controller Promotion

4.1 Server Preparation

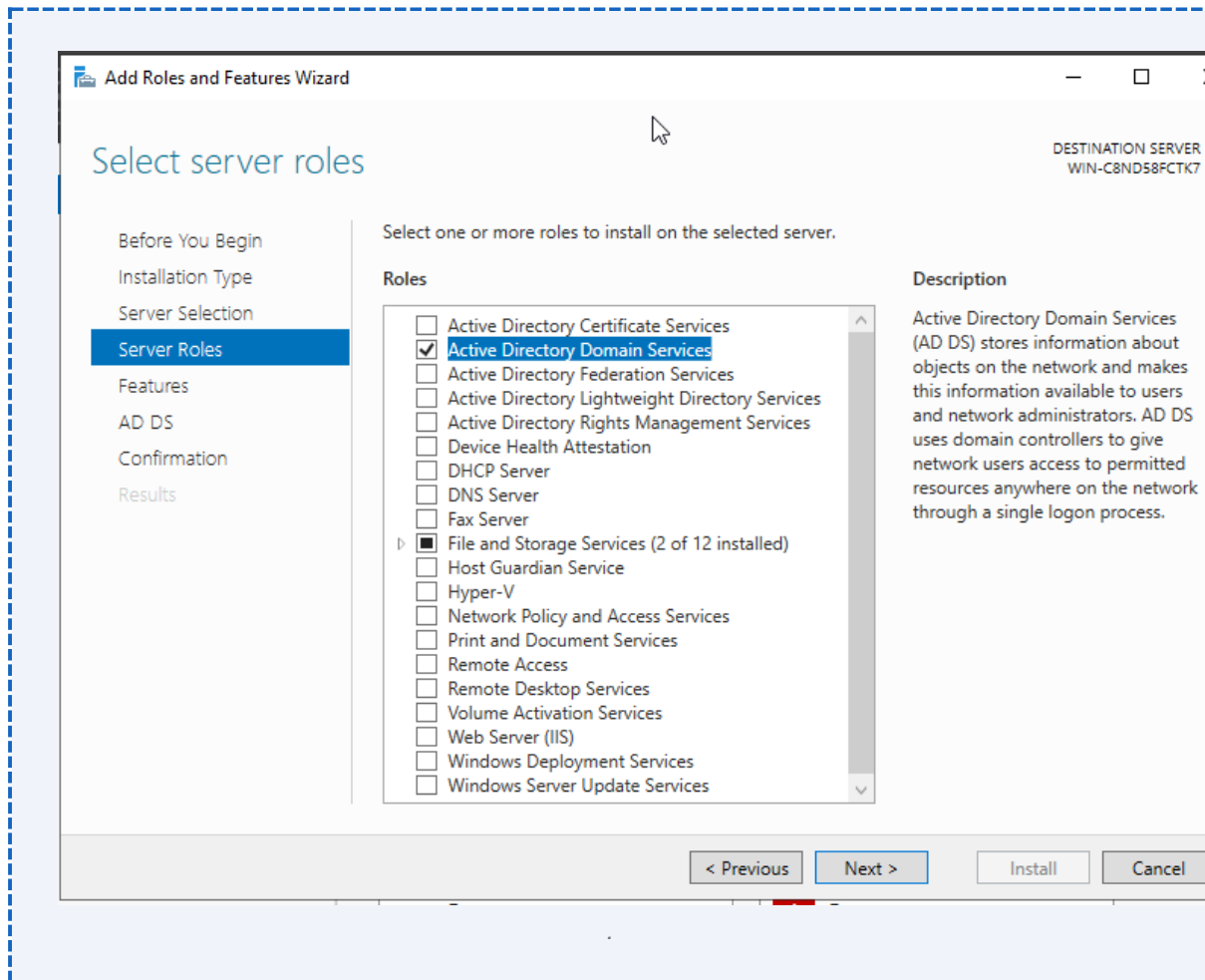
Prior to installing Active Directory Domain Services (AD DS), the server was configured with a static IP address and a consistent hostname (DC01), and network connectivity was verified. Windows Server 2022 was fully patched and all pending updates were applied to establish a stable and secure baseline.

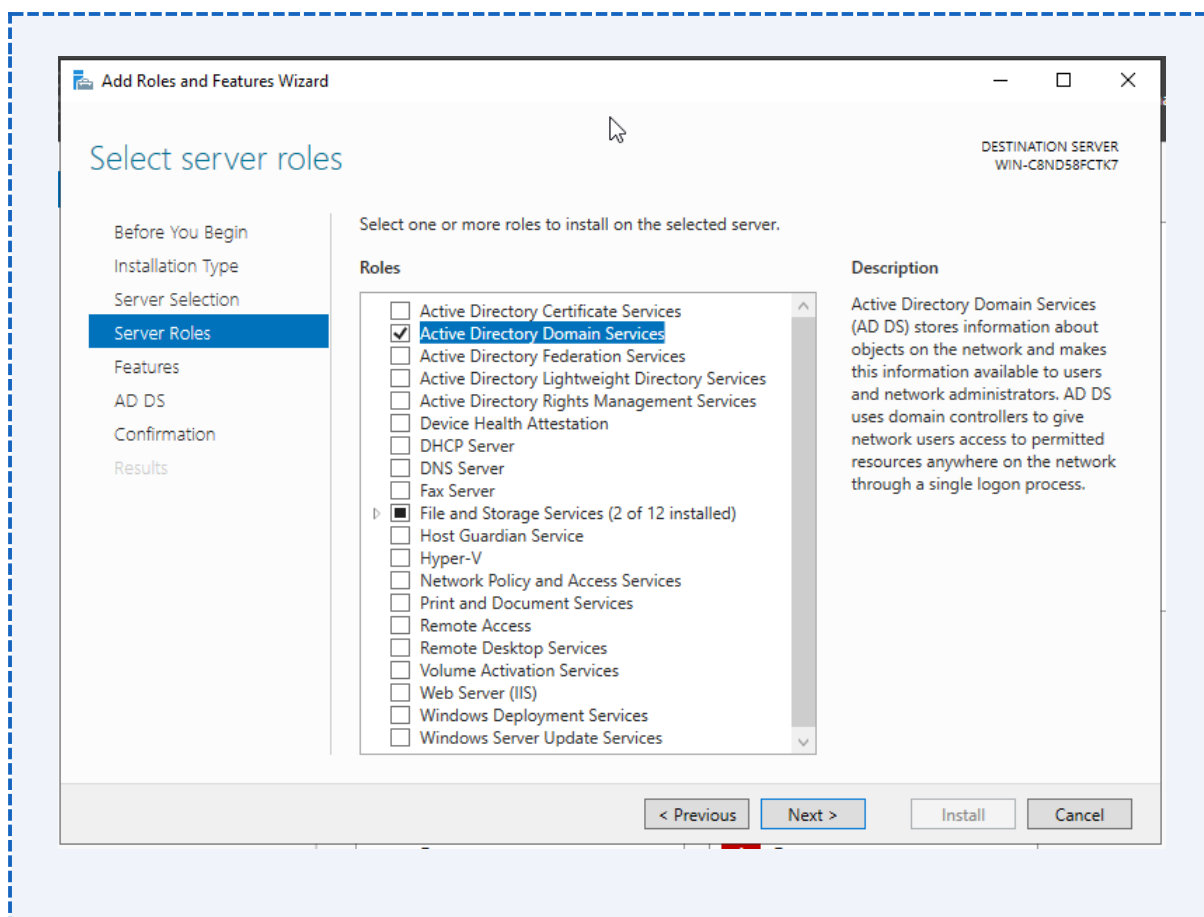


4.2 AD DS Role Installation

The Active Directory Domain Services role was installed via Server Manager using the Add Roles and Features Wizard. The following role and associated features were selected:

- Role: Active Directory Domain Services
- Feature: Group Policy Management (automatically included)
- Feature: Remote Server Administration Tools — AD DS Tools
- Role: DNS Server (selected to support AD-integrated DNS)

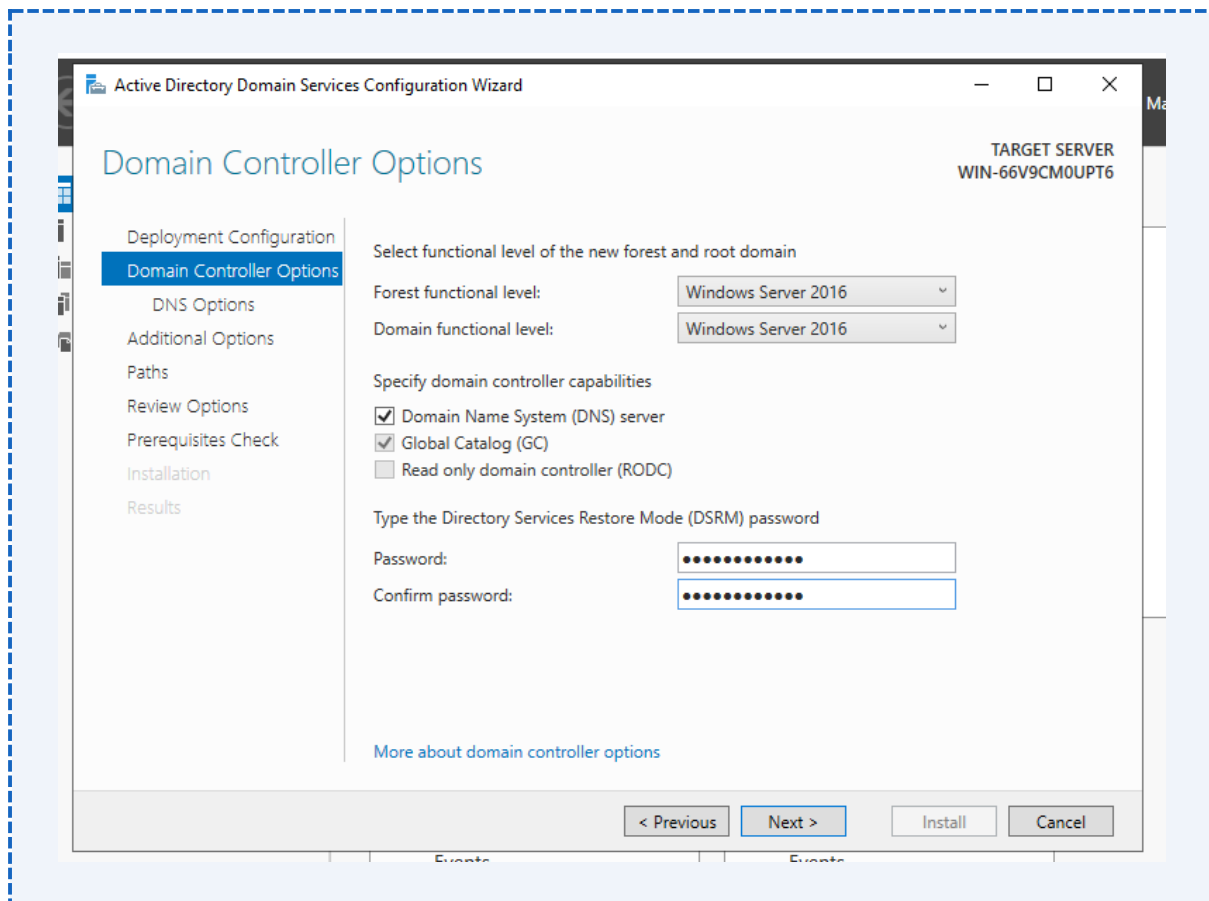




4.3 Domain Controller Promotion — New Forest

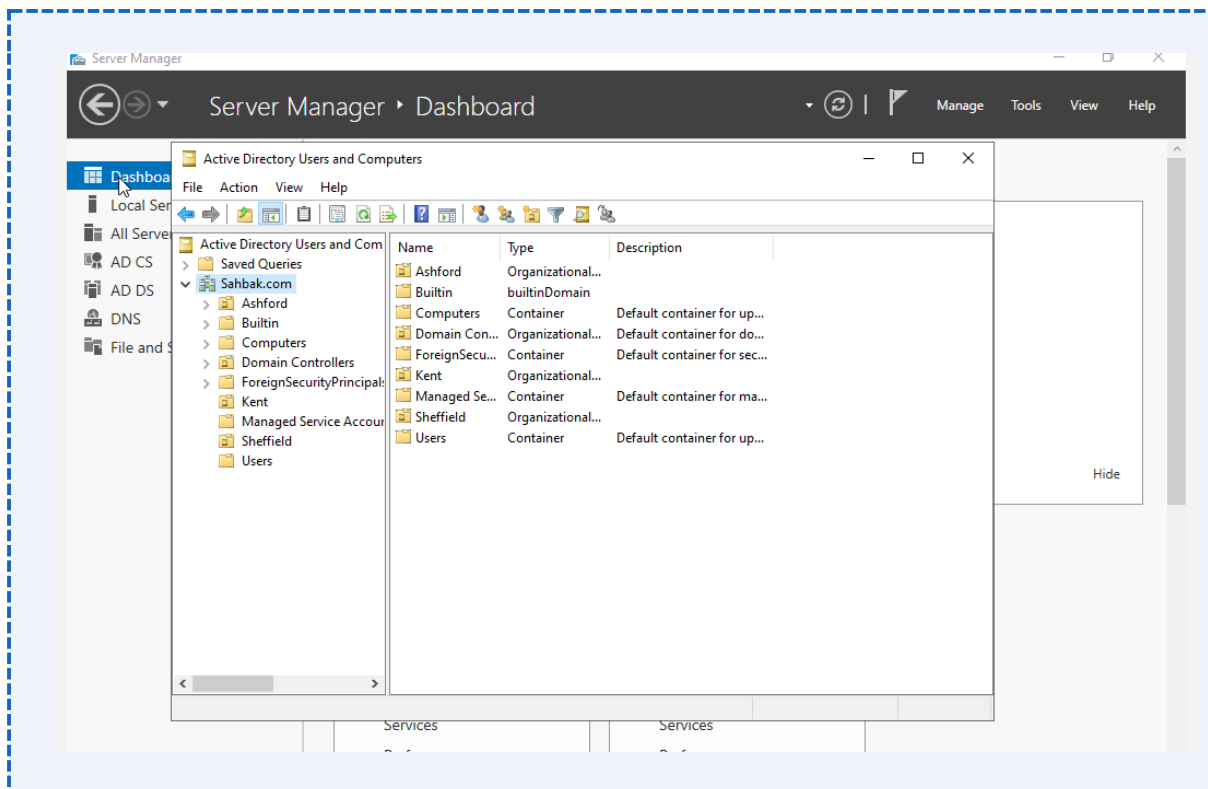
Following role installation, the server was promoted to a Domain Controller using the Active Directory Domain Services Configuration Wizard. The following configuration was applied:

Configuration Parameter	Value Applied
Deployment Operation	Add a new forest
Root Domain Name	Sahbak.com
Forest Functional Level	Windows Server 2016
Domain Functional Level	Windows Server 2016
Domain Controller Capabilities	DNS Server, Global Catalog (GC)
Directory Services Restore Mode (DSRM)	A strong Directory Services Restore Mode (DSRM) password was configured and stored securely
NetBIOS Domain Name	SAHBAK
AD DS Database Path	C:\Windows\NTDS
SYSVOL Path	C:\Windows\SYSVOL
DNS Delegation	Not created (single-domain lab environment)



Upon completion of the configuration wizard, the server performed an automatic restart. Post-restart verification confirmed:

- AD DS services, including NTDS, KDC, and Netlogon, were running and configured to start automatically.
- DNS zones for sahbak.com and _msdcs.sahbak.com were created and are resolving correctly
- SYSVOL and NETLOGON shares were accessible from the network.
- Default Active Directory objects, including the Domain Controllers OU, Built-in container, and Users container, were present in Active Directory Users and Computers (ADUC).



Administrative Note

Following Domain Controller promotion, the built-in Administrator account was secured with a strong complex password, and a separate Domain Admin account was created for routine administrative tasks. This reduces reliance on the built-in Administrator account and supports the principle of least privilege.

5. Organisational Unit (OU) Design

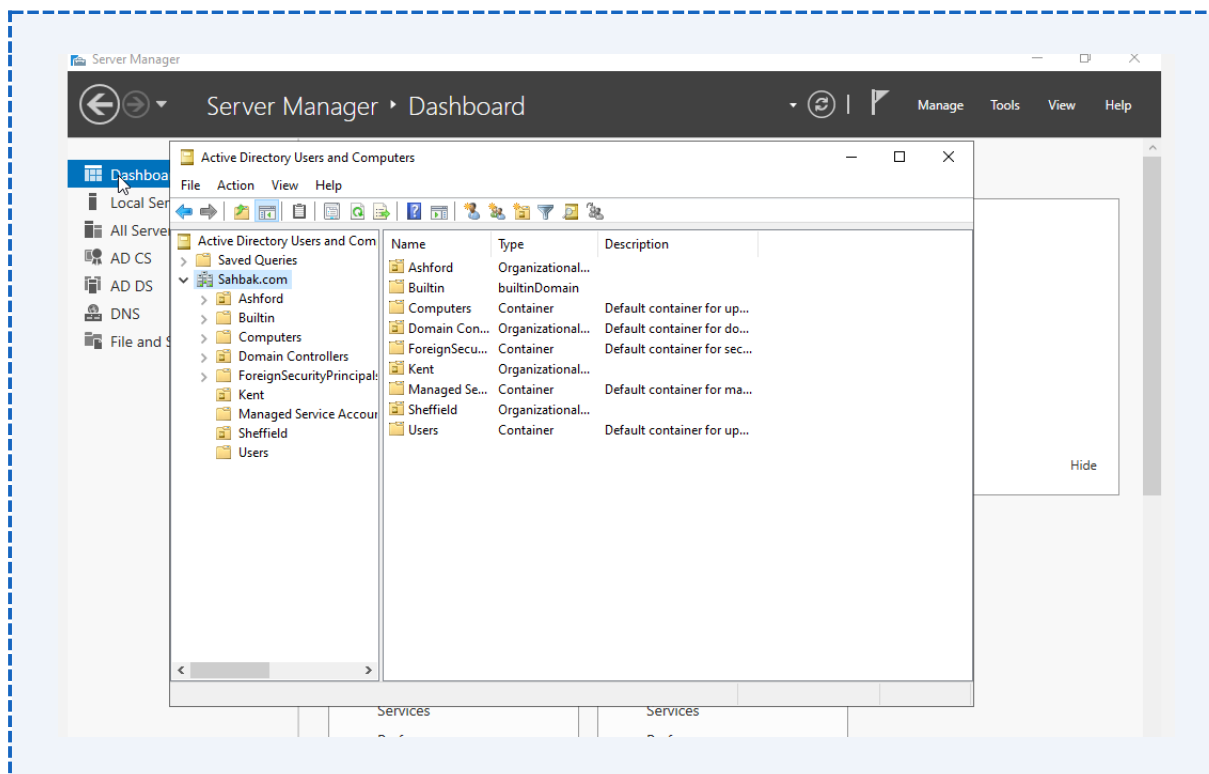
5.1 Design Rationale

The Organisational Unit hierarchy was designed to reflect Sahbak's geographic office locations, enabling location-scoped Group Policy application, delegated administration, and clear separation of identity objects. This mirrors industry-standard practice of building OU structures that support both policy inheritance and delegated administrative control, which are core principles in enterprise IAM environments.

5.2 OU Hierarchy

Three top-level OUs were created directly under the sahbak.com domain root, each representing a physical office location:

OU Name	Distinguished Name (DN)	Purpose
Ashford	OU=Ashford,DC=sahbak,DC=com	Users, groups and workstations for the Ashford office
Kent	OU=Kent,DC=sahbak,DC=com	Users, groups and workstations for the Kent office
Sheffield	OU=Sheffield,DC=sahbak,DC=com	Users, groups and workstations for the Sheffield office



GPO Inheritance Principle

GPOs linked at the domain level apply to all three OUs by inheritance. OU-specific GPOs can be linked at the individual OU level to override or extend domain-level policy for specific locations or user populations — a pattern used in this project for targeted access restriction policies.

5.3 OU Structure Diagram

Sahbak.com (Domain Root)

```
|
+-- OU=Ashford
|   +-- [Groups: Human Resources, IT Department]
|   +-- [Users: 4 accounts]
|
+-- OU=Kent
|   +-- [Groups: Logistic, Procurement]
|   +-- [Users: 4 accounts]
|
+-- OU=Sheffield
|   +-- [Groups: Audit, Finance]
|   +-- [Users: 4 accounts]
```

6. Identity Lifecycle — User & Group Provisioning

6.1 Naming Convention & UPN Standard

A consistent, enterprise-grade naming convention was applied across all identities to support IAM governance, audit readiness, and integration with downstream systems such as Microsoft Identity Manager (MIM) and ITSM tooling.

UPN Naming Convention

Format: firstname.lastname@sahbak.com Example: john.warren@sahbak.com

This convention provides each user with a consistent and easily identifiable User Principal Name (UPN) based on their first name and surname. It supports simplified identity lookup, user administration, auditing, and future integration with identity governance and provisioning systems.

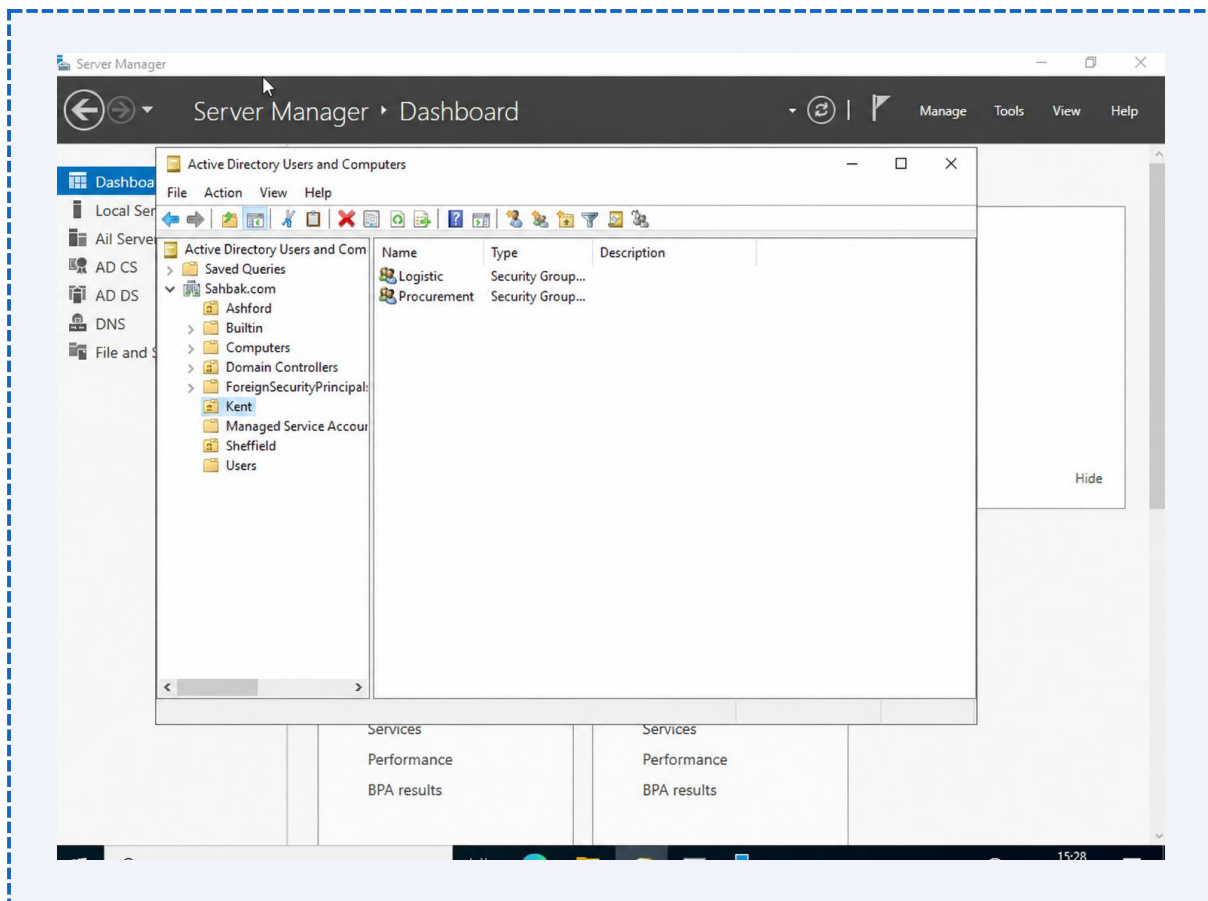
The UPN format serves multiple IAM governance purposes:

- Provides a consistent and predictable login naming convention
- Simplifies user provisioning, administration, and identity lookup
- Supports consistent attribute mapping for future identity synchronisation
- Improves audit and log correlation across Active Directory, SIEM, and ITSM systems

6.2 Group Structure per OU

Two security groups were created within each OU, each reflecting a business function. All groups are Global Security Groups, aligned with RBAC best practice (resource access assigned at the group level, not to individual users).

OU	Group Name	Group DN	Group Type / Scope
Ashford	Human Resources	CN=Human Resources,OU=Ashford,DC=sahbak,DC=com	Global Security Group
Ashford	IT Department	CN=IT Department,OU=Ashford,DC=sahbak,DC=com	Global Security Group
Kent	Logistic	CN=Logistic,OU=Kent,DC=sahbak,DC=com	Global Security Group
Kent	Procurement	CN=Procurement,OU=Kent,DC=sahbak,DC=com	Global Security Group
Sheffield	Audit	CN=Audit,OU=Sheffield,DC=sahbak,DC=com	Global Security Group
Sheffield	Finance	CN=Finance,OU=Sheffield,DC=sahbak,DC=com	Global Security Group

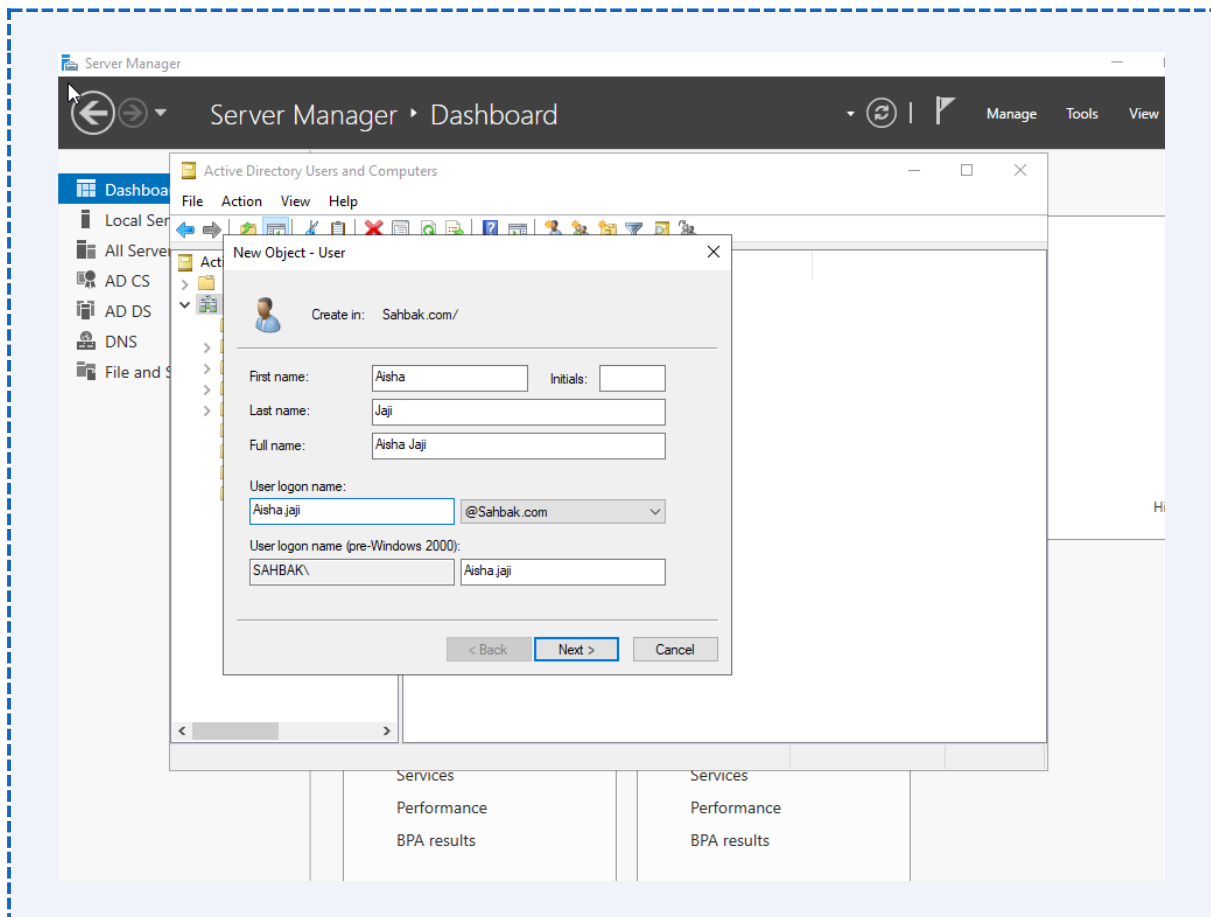


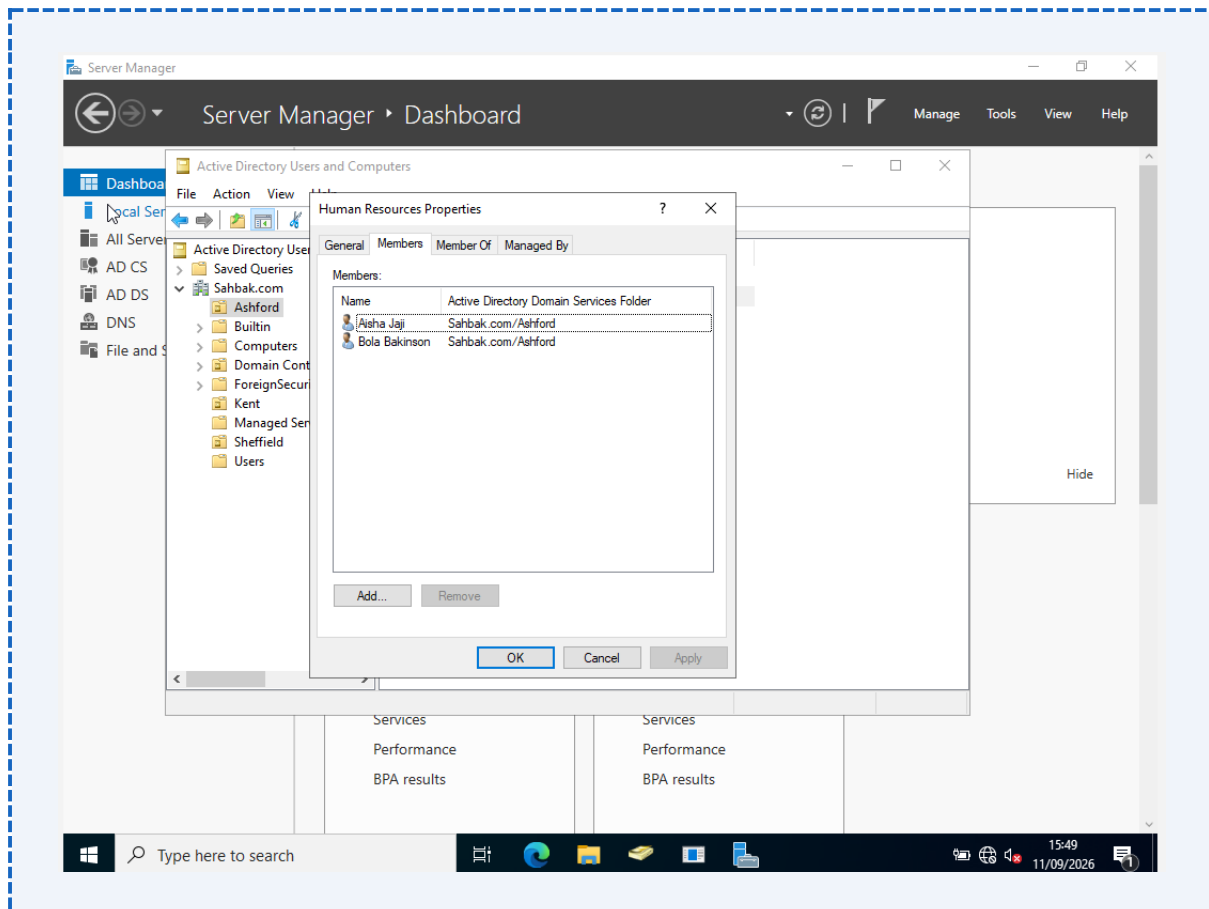
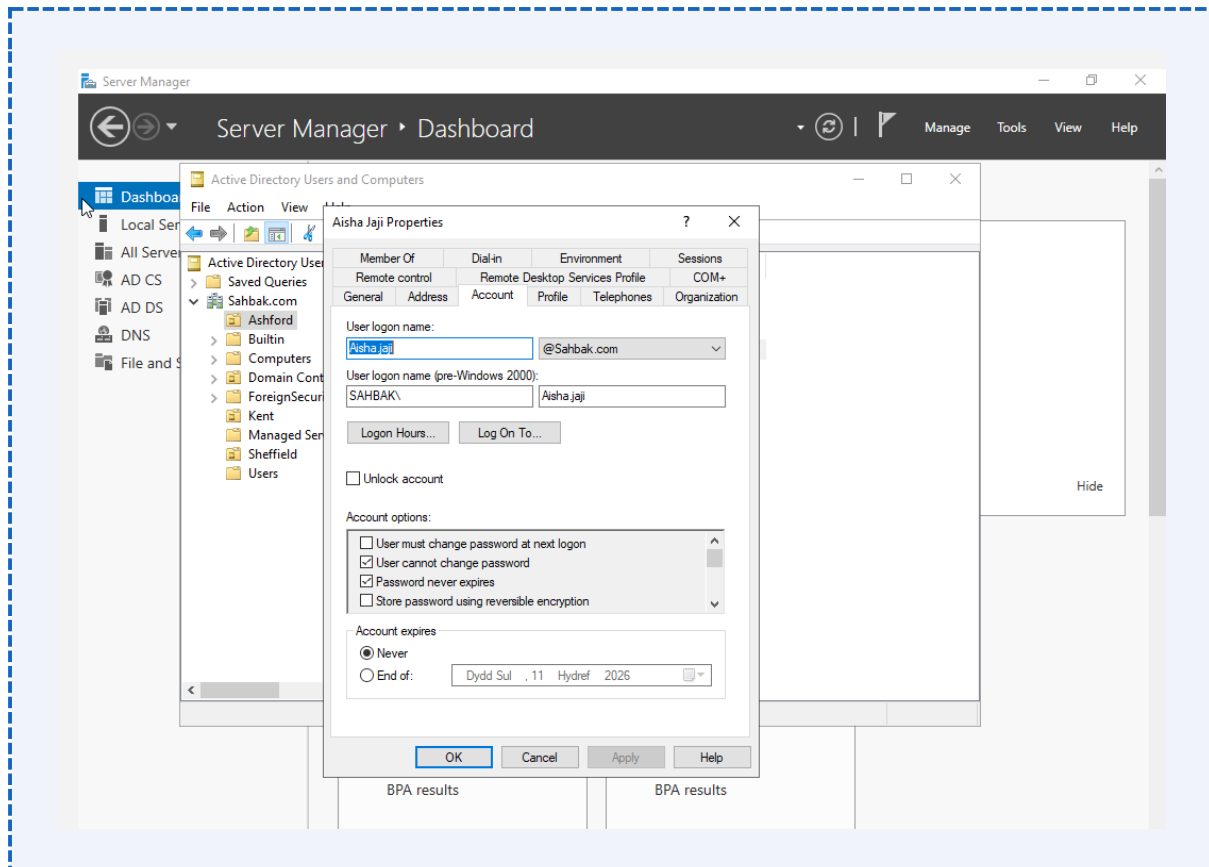
6.3 Full User Provisioning Register

Two user accounts were created per group (12 accounts total). Each user was placed in the OU corresponding to their location and added to their group as a member. The table below constitutes the full identity provisioning register for the Sahbak.com domain

User Principal Name (UPN)	OU	Group Membership	Display Name / Role
bola.bakinson@sahbak.com	Ashford	Human Resources	Bola Bakinson — HR Assistant
aisha.jaji@sahbak.com	Ashford	Human Resources	Aisha Jaji — HR Officer
oyin.thomas@sahbak.com	Ashford	IT Department	Oyin Thomas — IT Support Technician
daniel.smith@sahbak.com	Ashford	IT Department	Daniel Smith — Systems Administrator
john.warren@sahbak.com	Kent	Logistic	John Warren — Logistics Coordinator
ahmed.tinubu@sahbak.com	Kent	Logistic	Ahmed Tinubu — Logistics Officer
sam.wallace@sahbak.com	Kent	Procurement	Sam Wallace — Procurement Analyst
emily.carter@sahbak.com	Kent	Procurement	Emily Carter — Procurement Officer

waliul.islam@sahbak.com	Sheffield	Audit	Waliul Islam — Internal Auditor
grace.miller@sahbak.com	Sheffield	Audit	Grace Miller — Audit Associate
borice.koley@sahbak.com	Sheffield	Finance	Borice Koley — Finance Officer
kola.abiola@sahbak.com	Sheffield	Finance	Kola Abiola — Finance Analyst



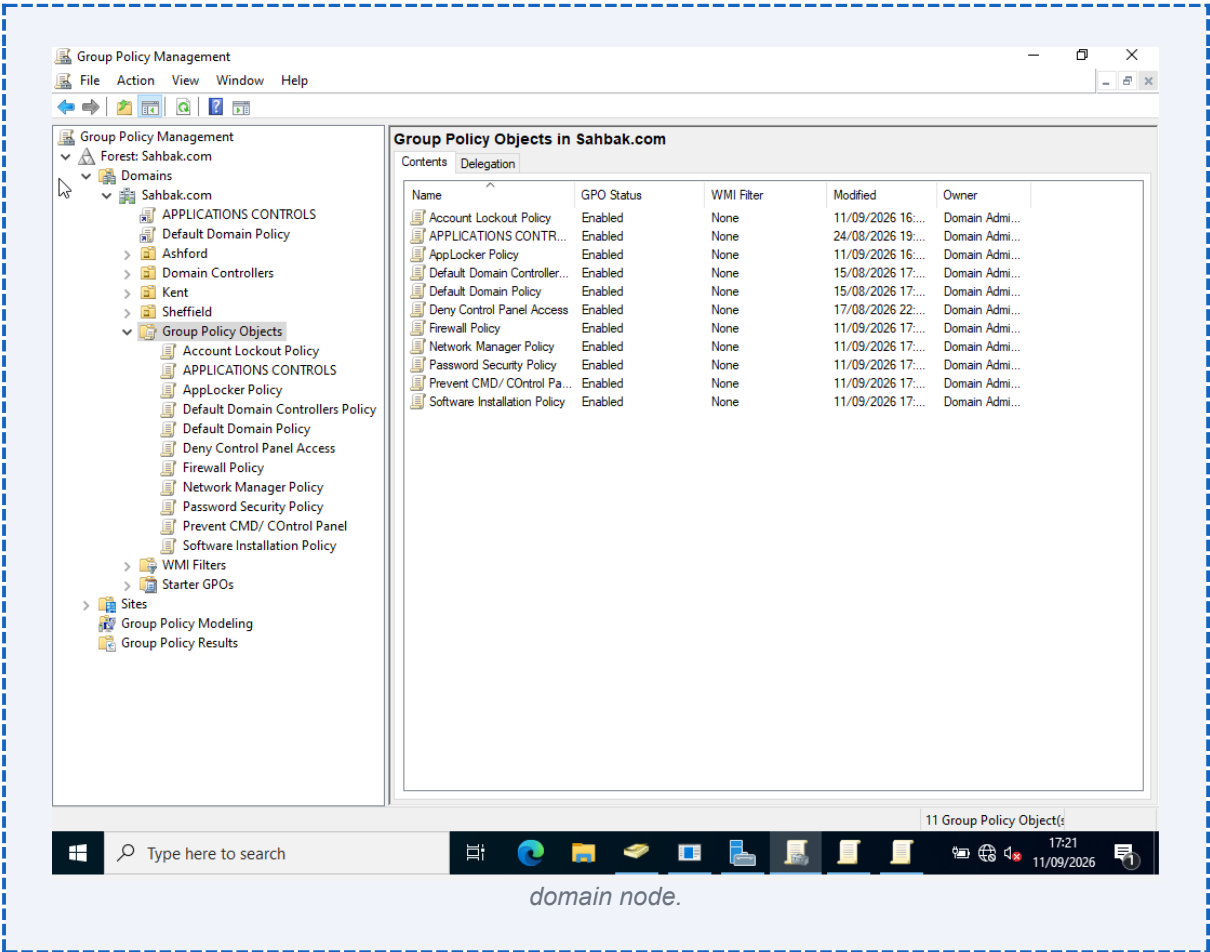


Account Attribute Standards

All accounts were provisioned using a consistent identity standard: Account Enabled = True | Password must be changed at next logon = False for the lab environment | User cannot change password = False | UPN configured using the `firstname.lastname@sahbak.com` naming convention | Description field populated with the user's job role | Department attribute aligned to the relevant security group or business function | Manager attribute configured where applicable.

7. Group Policy Object (GPO) Design & Implementation

All GPOs were created and managed via the Group Policy Management Console (GPMC). Each GPO was created with a descriptive name, configured with specific settings, linked at the appropriate scope, and validated using the Group Policy Results (GPRESULT) and Group Policy Modelling tools.



7.1 Password Security Policy GPO

7.1.1 Purpose

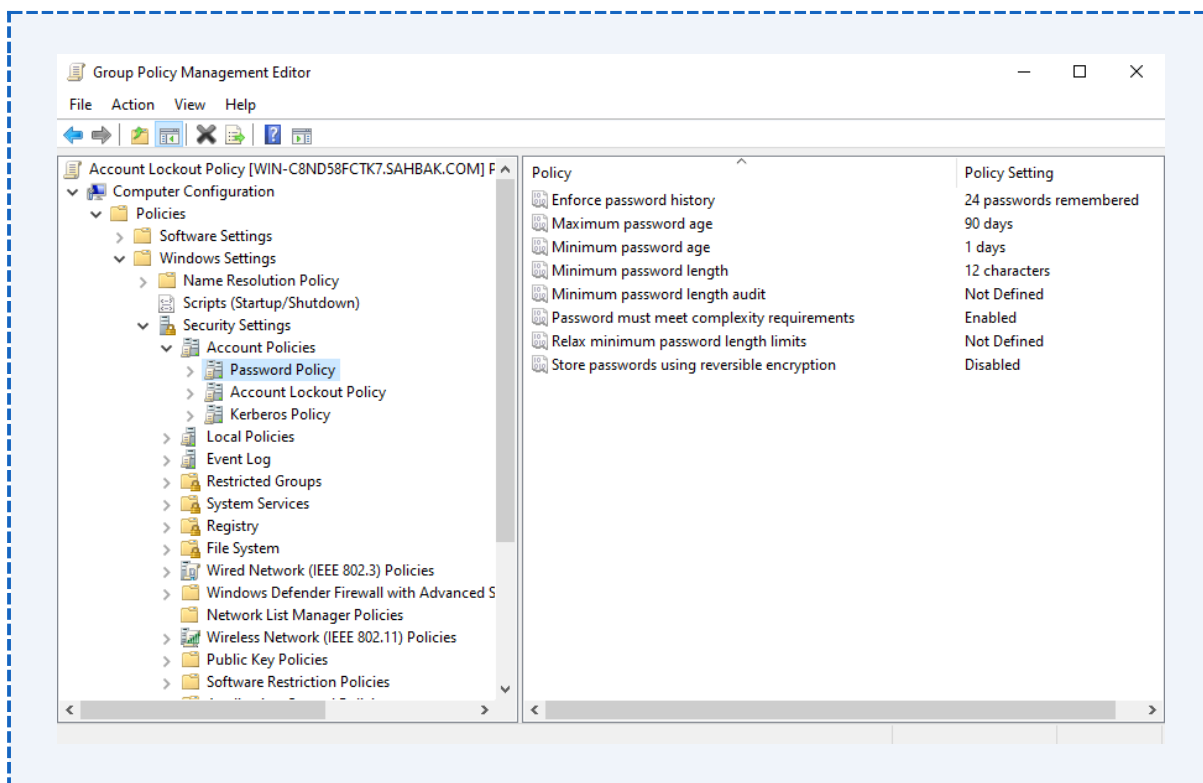
The Password Security Policy GPO enforces password complexity, minimum length, password history, and password-age requirements across the Sahbak domain. For domain user accounts, the password policy must be applied at the domain level so that the settings are enforced consistently across the Sahbak domain. This project implemented a dedicated, clearly named GPO linked to the domain to make the policy intent explicit and auditable — a best practice in enterprise environments.

7.1.2 GPO Configuration — Computer Configuration Path

Path: Computer Configuration > Policies > Windows Settings > Security Settings > Account Policies > Password Policy

Policy Setting	Configured Value	IAM Rationale
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Enforce password history	24 passwords remembered	Prevents users from cycling back to previous passwords, reducing reuse risk
Maximum password age	90 days	Limits the window of exposure for compromised credentials
Minimum password age	1 day	Prevents immediate cycling to bypass history enforcement
Minimum password length	12 characters	Increases resistance to password guessing and brute-force attacks by preventing the use of short passwords.
Password must meet complexity requirements	Enabled	Requires uppercase, lowercase, digit, and special character mix
Store passwords using reversible encryption	Disabled	Prevents clear-text password storage — critical security control

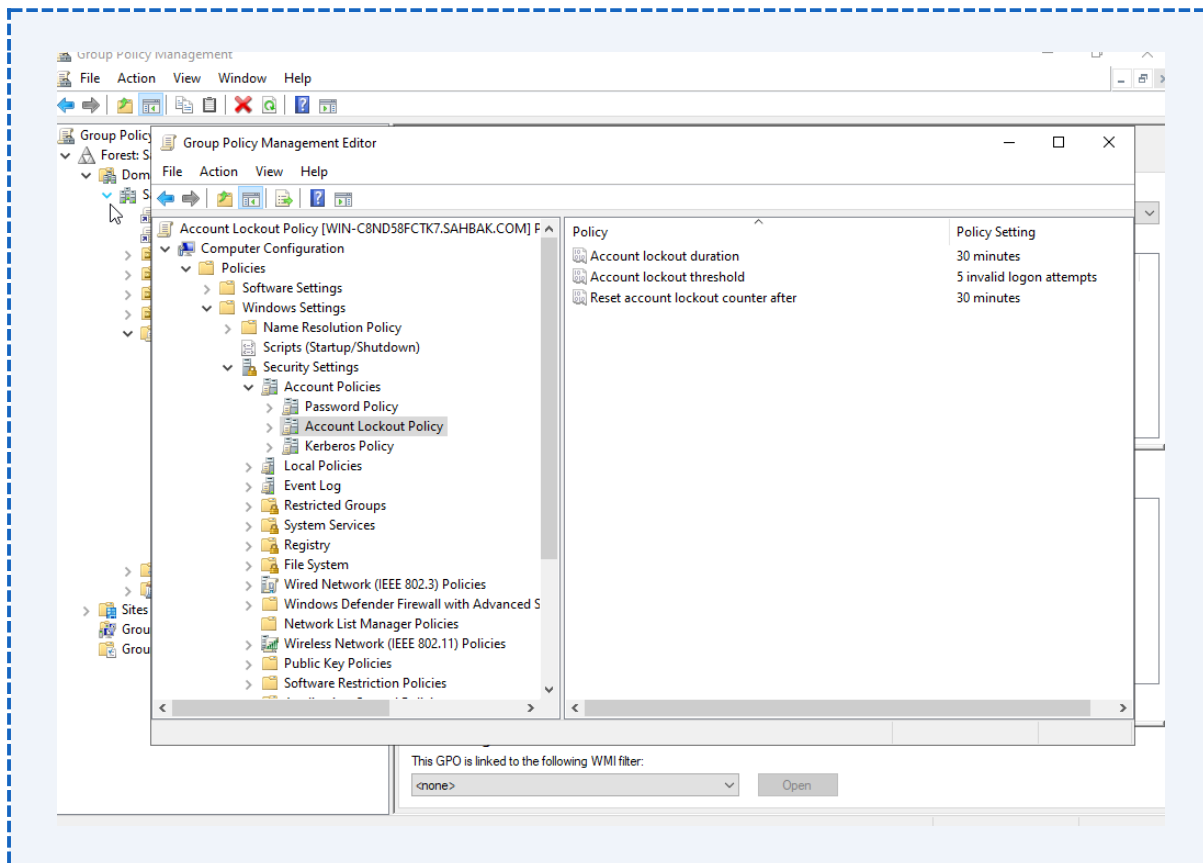


7.1.3 Account Lockout Policy

Path: Computer Configuration > Policies > Windows Settings > Security Settings > Account Policies > Account Lockout Policy

Policy Setting	Configured Value	IAM Rationale
Account lockout threshold	5 invalid attempts	Prevents brute-force and credential stuffing attacks

Account lockout duration	30 minutes	Auto-unlock reduces helpdesk burden while providing cooling-off period
Reset account lockout counter after	30 minutes	Resets the failed logon counter after 30 minutes without additional failed sign-in attempts



7.1.4 Linkage & Security Filtering

- GPO linked to: sahbak.com (domain root)
- Link order: 1 (highest precedence at domain level)
- Enforcement: Enabled (prevents child OUs from blocking inheritance)
- Security Filtering: Authenticated Users (applies to all domain user and computer accounts)

7.2 Restricted Access GPO — Control Panel & CMD Lockdown

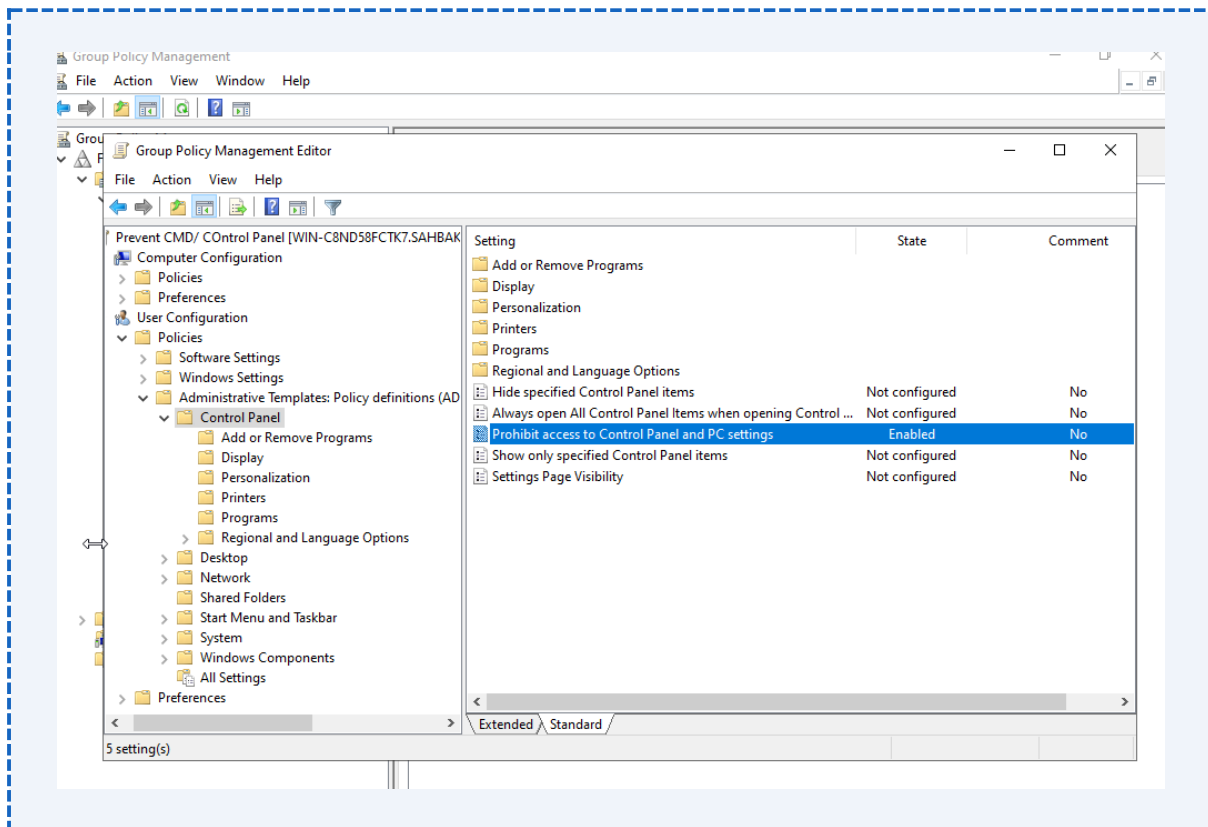
7.2.1 Purpose

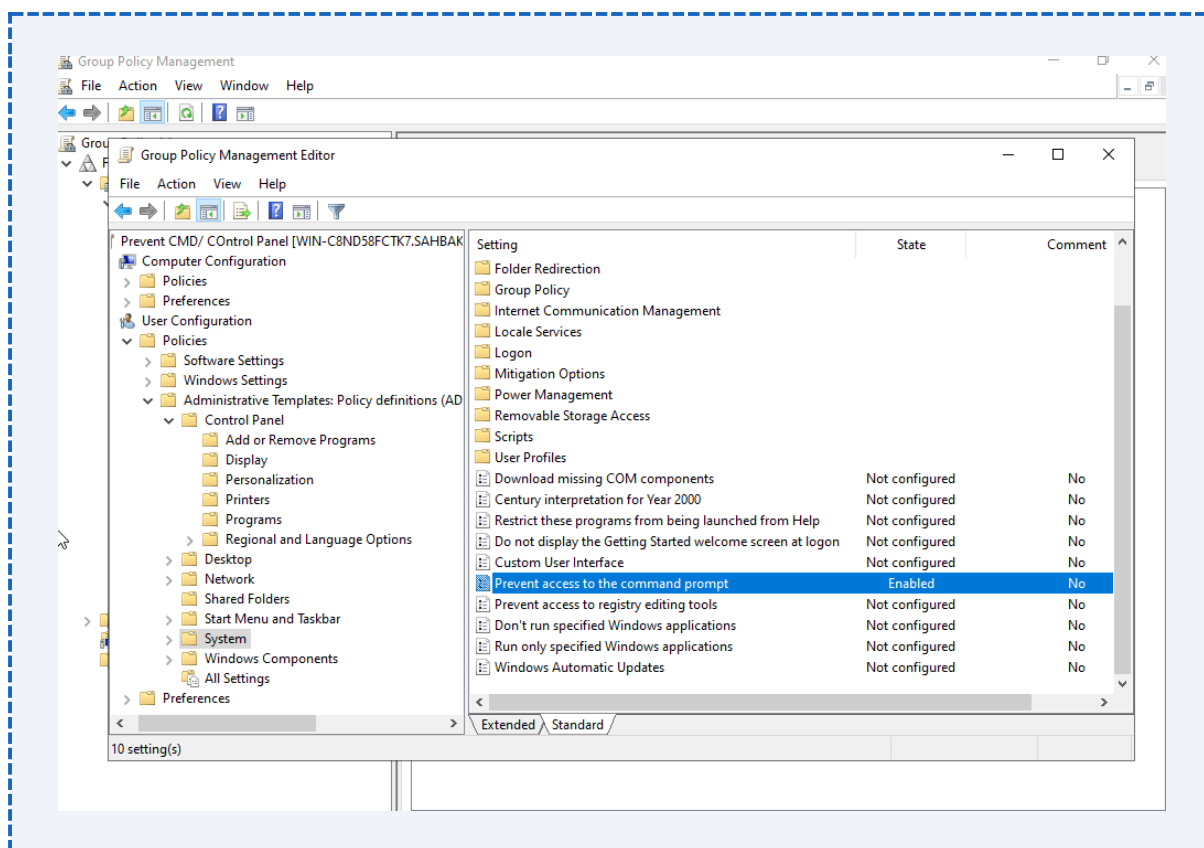
This GPO was created to restrict a defined subset of standard users from accessing the Windows Control Panel and the Command Prompt (cmd.exe). This addresses a common IAM control requirement: limiting access to system configuration tools for non-administrative users, preventing unauthorised system changes and reducing opportunities for unauthorised system changes and misuse of command-line tools.

7.2.2 GPO Configuration — User Configuration

Path: User Configuration > Policies > Administrative Templates

Policy Path	Setting	Value & Effect
Control Panel and Settings	Prohibit access to Control Panel and PC Settings	Enabled — removes Control Panel from Start Menu; direct access attempts produce an access denied message
System > Prevent access to the command prompt	Prevent access to the command prompt	Enabled — blocks cmd.exe launch; also disables running of batch scripts to prevent script-based bypass
System > Prevent access to the command prompt	Disable the command prompt script processing also ?	Yes — ensures batch files (.bat, .cmd) are also blocked, preventing indirect cmd access





7.2.3 Linkage & Targeting

- GPO linked to: sahbak.com (domain root) — applies domain-wide by inheritance
- Security Filtering: Applied to the intended standard-user security group; selected administrative or IT users can be excluded by denying the Apply Group Policy permission where required.
- WMI Filter: Optional — can be added to scope to specific machine types (e.g., standard workstations only, not servers)

Least Privilege Note

Members of the designated IT administration group were excluded from this GPO's application where required by configuring the group with Deny — Apply Group Policy. This allows authorised IT administrators to retain access to Command Prompt and Control Panel for legitimate support and system-management tasks, while standard users remain restricted.

7.3 Additional GPOs — IAM Security Hardening

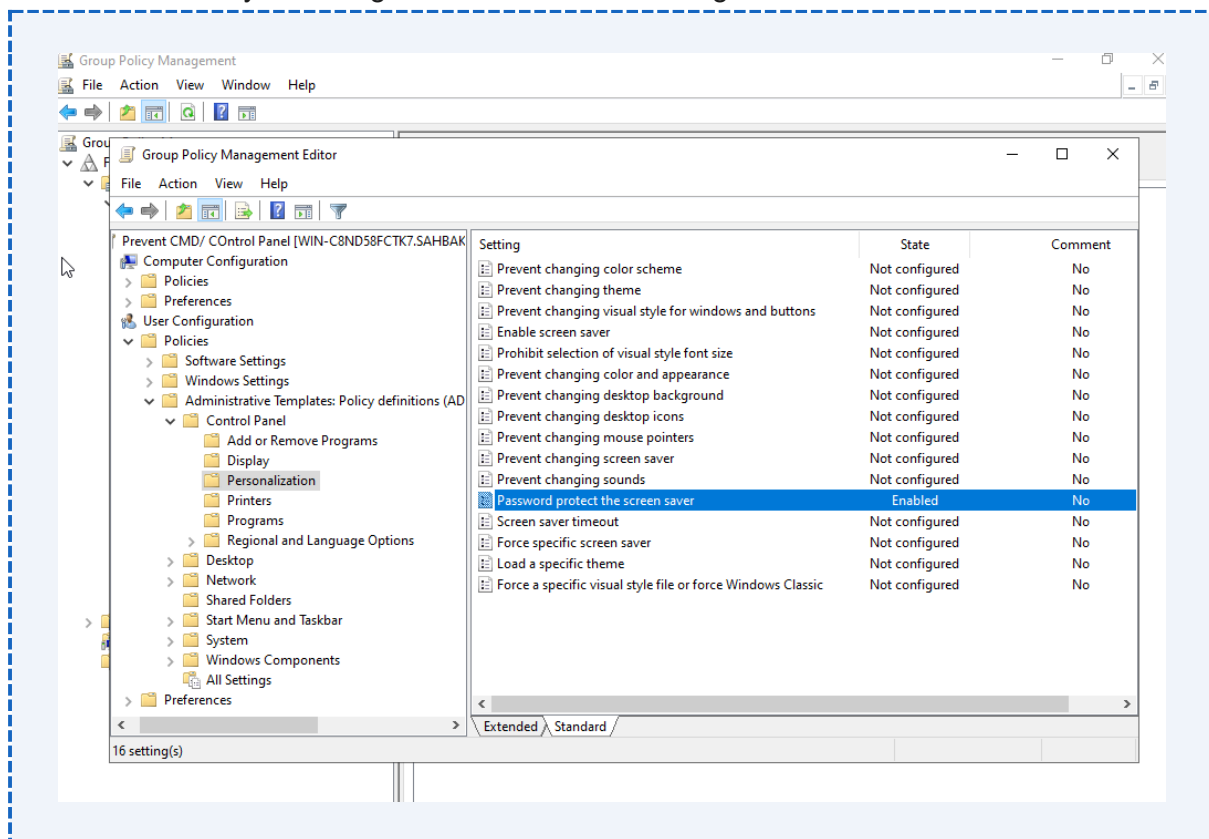
The following additional GPOs were designed and implemented to strengthen the Sahbak domain through practical IAM and endpoint security hardening controls commonly used in enterprise Active Directory environments.

GPO 3: Screen Lock & Idle Session Timeout

Path: User Configuration > Policies > Administrative Templates > Control Panel > Personalisation

Setting	Value	Rationale
Enable screen saver	Enabled	Forces screensaver activation on idle
Screen saver timeout	600 seconds (10 minutes)	Locks unattended sessions, preventing physical access exploitation
Password protect the screen saver	Enabled	Requires re-authentication after lock — critical physical security control

- GPO linked to: sahbak.com (domain root)
- Security Filtering: Authenticated Users (all standard users)
- IAM Alignment: Reduces the risk of unauthorised access to unattended authenticated sessions by enforcing automatic session locking and re-authentication.

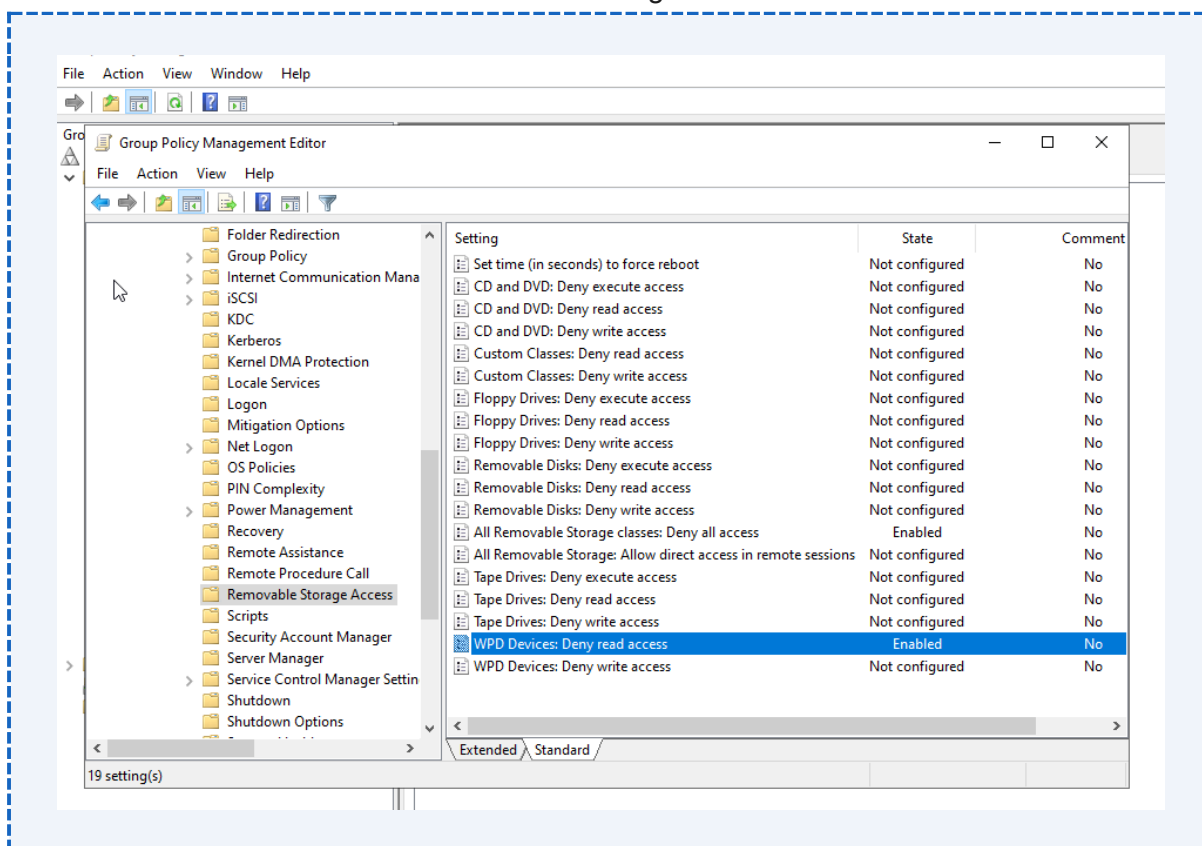


GPO 4: Removable Media / USB Storage Block

Path: Computer Configuration > Policies > Administrative Templates > System > Removable Storage Access

Setting	Value	Rationale
All Removable Storage classes: Deny all access	Enabled	Prevents data exfiltration and introduction of malware via USB devices
WPD Devices: Deny read access	Enabled	Blocks Windows Portable Devices (phones, cameras) from reading domain data

- GPO linked to: OU=Ashford, OU=Kent, OU=Sheffield (applied at each OU)
- Security Filtering: Authenticated Users, with designated IT administrators excluded where maintenance access is required.
- IAM Alignment: Supports Data Loss Prevention (DLP) by reducing the risk of data exfiltration and malware introduction through removable media.

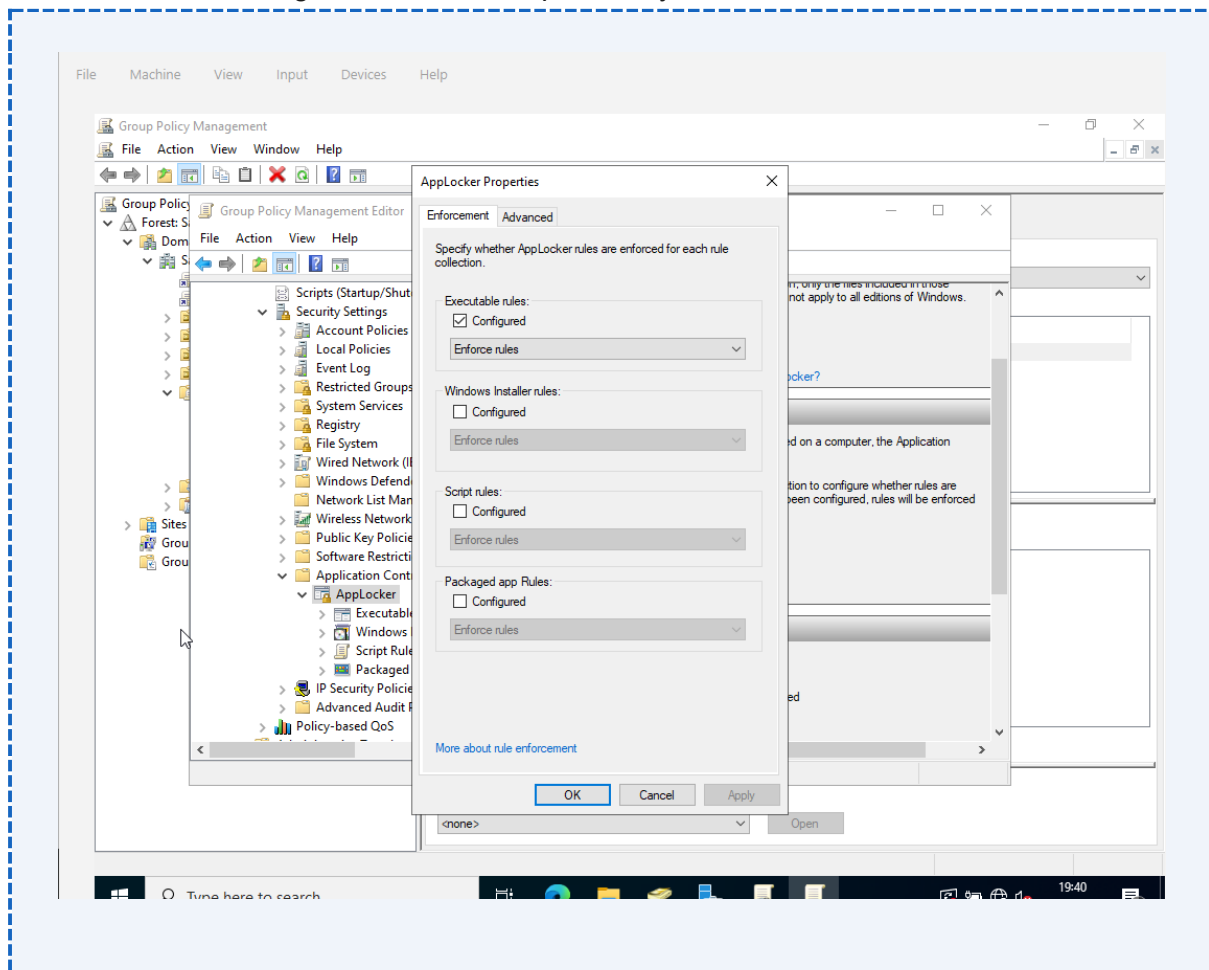


GPO 5: AppLocker Policy — Application Execution Control

Path: Computer Configuration > Policies > Windows Settings > Security Settings > Application Control Policies > AppLocker

Rule Type	Configuration	Rationale
Executable Rules (Default)	Allow standard Windows and Program Files locations	Allows normal operating system and approved application execution
Executable Rules (Deny)	Deny %SYSTEM32%\cmd.exe for the targeted user/group	Prevents unauthorised Command Prompt execution
Script Rules	Allow signed scripts only	Prevents unsigned PowerShell and VBScript execution

- GPO linked to: sahbak.com (domain root)
- Application Identity Service must be running for AppLocker enforcement
- IAM Alignment: Restricts unauthorised application execution and reduces the risk of users launching administrative or potentially unsafe tools.



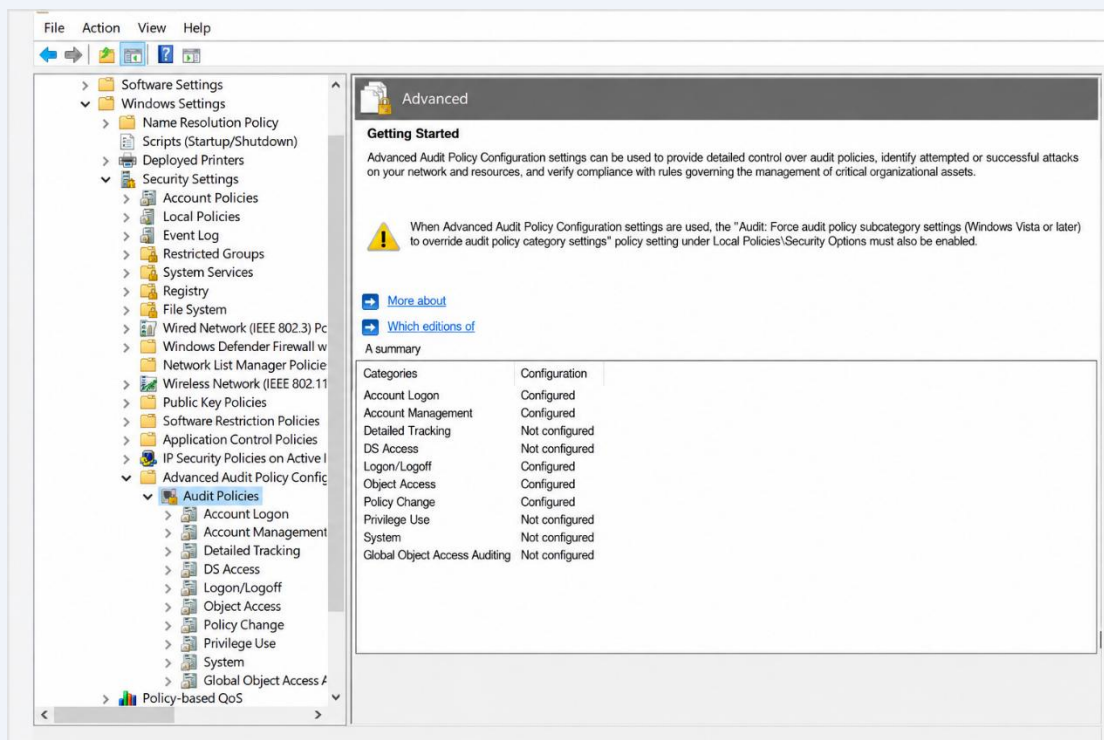
GPO 6: Audit Policy — Identity Event Logging

Path: Computer Configuration > Policies > Windows Settings > Security Settings > Advanced Audit Policy Configuration

Audit Category	Setting	IAM Rationale
Account Logon — Credential Validation	Success and Failure	Detects password spraying, brute force, and credential theft attempts
Account Management — User Account Management	Success and Failure	Tracks account creation, deletion, password changes, and group modifications — core IAM audit requirement
Account Management — Security Group Management	Success	Logs all group membership changes for access governance review
Logon/Logoff — Logon	Success and Failure	Supports session tracking and anomalous access detection

Object Access — Directory Service Access	Success and Failure	Logs access to sensitive AD objects; supports privileged access monitoring
Policy Change — Authentication Policy Change	Success	Detects unauthorised GPO or domain policy modifications

- GPO linked to: sahbak.com (domain root) — applies to domain controllers and member systems within the linked scope
- Log size configured: Security event log expanded to 1GB to retain sufficient audit history
- IAM Alignment: Supports identity-related monitoring, incident investigation, and audit visibility for authentication, account-management, and policy-change events.



8. GPO Security Filtering & Scope Management

8.1 Overview

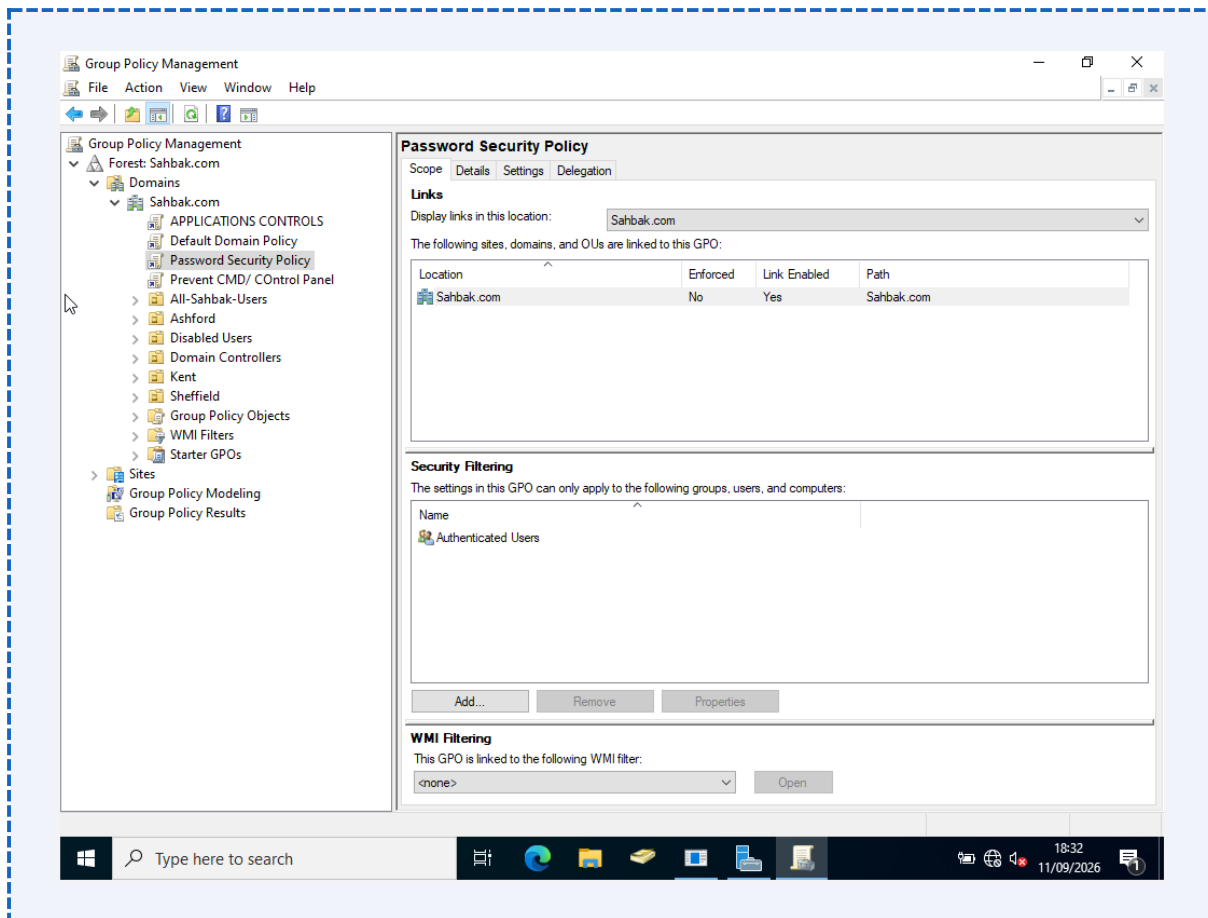
GPO Security Filtering is the mechanism by which a GPO's application is scoped to specific users, computers, or groups — overriding the default behaviour of applying to all Authenticated Users within the linked scope. This is a critical IAM control that ensures the right policies apply to the right identities without affecting administrative or service accounts that require exemption.

8.2 Security Filtering — Password Security Policy

The Password Security Policy GPO was configured with the following security filtering to ensure domain-wide application.

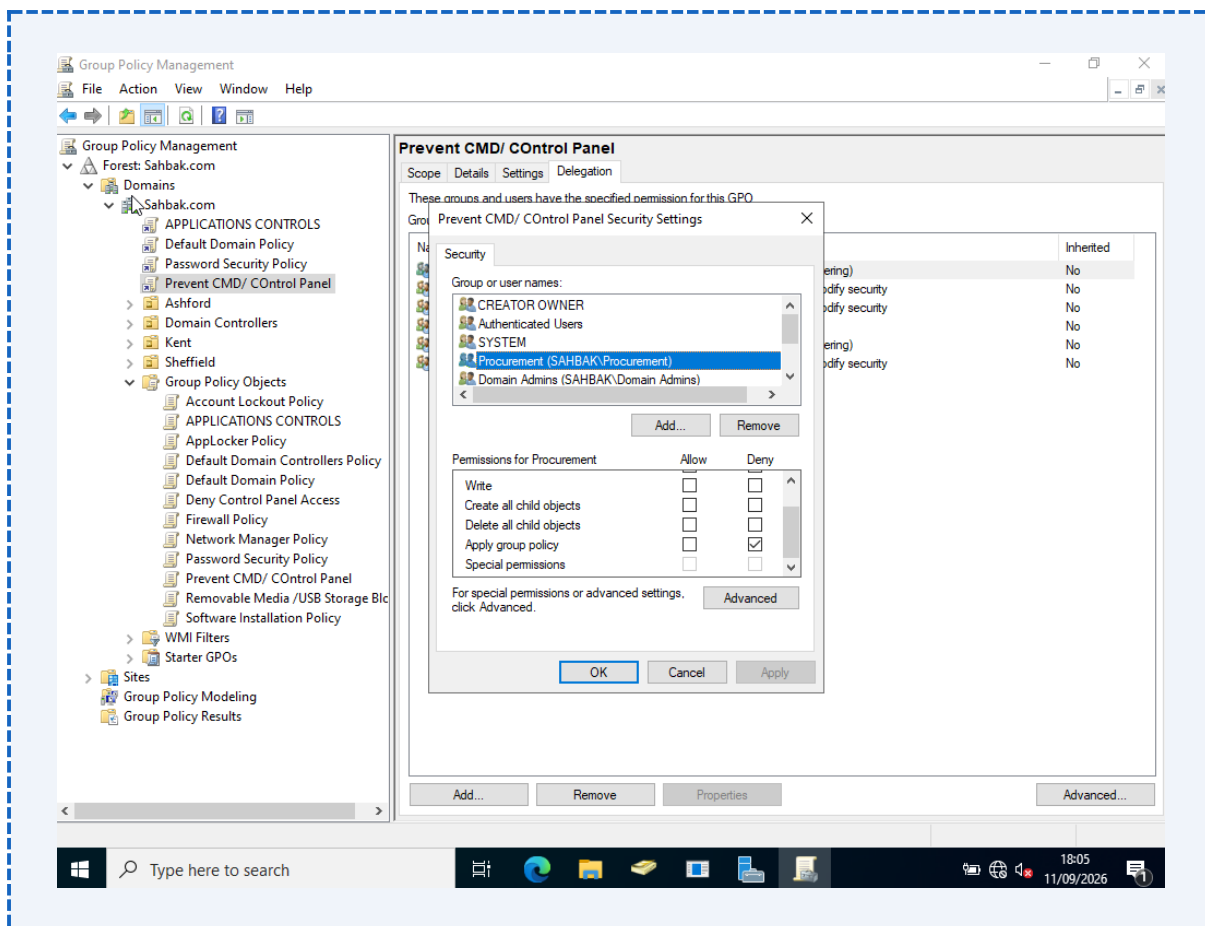
Principal	Permission Applied	Effect
Authenticated Users	Allow: Read, Apply Group Policy	Policy applies to authenticated domain users and computers across the Sahbak environment.

By retaining Authenticated Users with Read and Apply Group Policy permissions, the GPO can apply across the Sahbak domain within its linked scope, including users and computers in the Ashford, Kent, and Sheffield OUs.



8.3 Security Filtering — Restricted Access GPO (Control Panel & CMD)

Principal	Permission	Type	Effect
Authenticated Users	Read only	Allow	GPO remains readable but does not apply by default
All-Sahbak-Users	Read + Apply Group Policy	Allow	Policy applies to standard users in scope
Procurement	Apply Group Policy	Deny	Procurement members are explicitly excluded from the restriction
Domain Admins	Read / administrative access	Allow	Administrators retain management access to the GPO



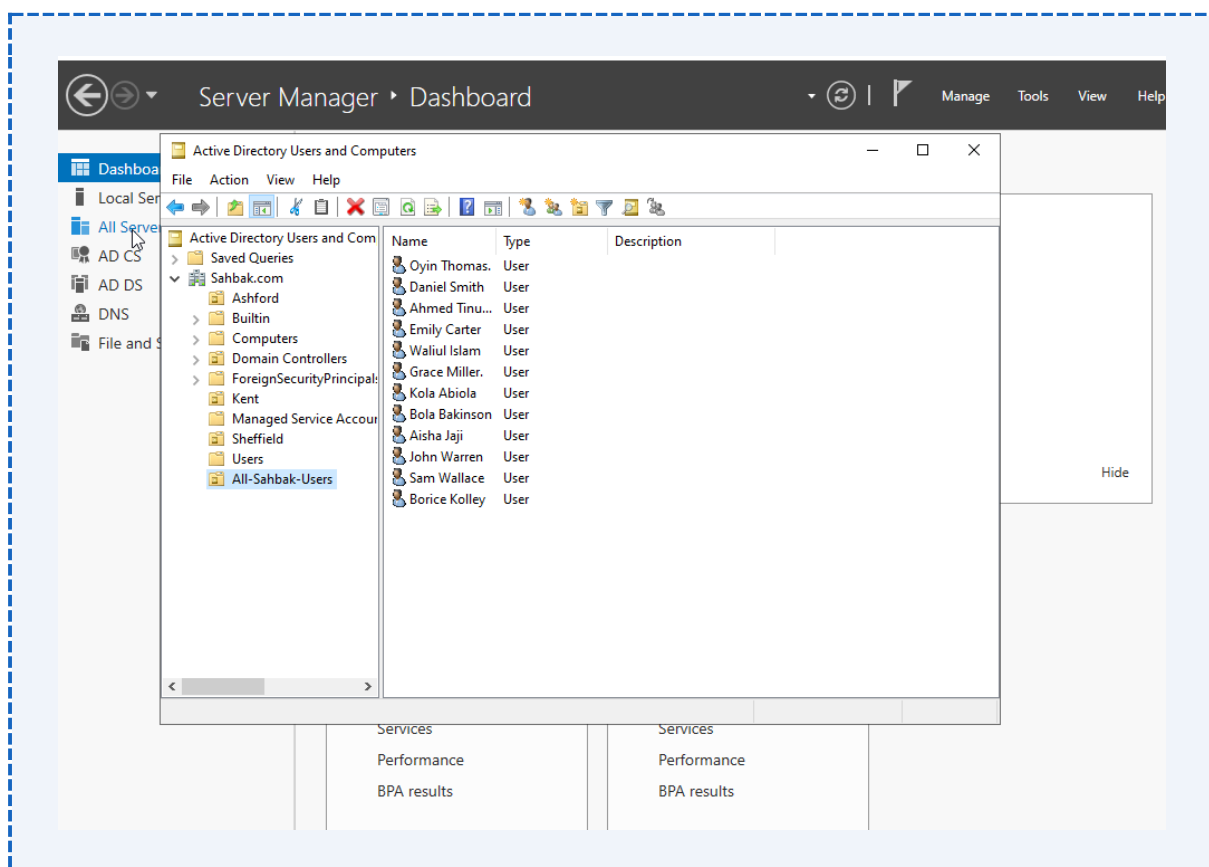
Security Filtering Best Practice

Removing 'Authenticated Users' from the Apply Group Policy permission (while retaining Read) is the recommended Microsoft practice for scoping GPOs. This prevents the GPO from applying broadly to all authenticated users by default, while allowing a specific security group to be added as the intended target. This approach avoids the WMI filter overhead and provides clear, auditable access control over policy application.

8.4 All-Sahbak-Users Group

A dedicated security group — All-Sahbak-Users — was created to act as a central GPO security-filtering group for policies intended for the standard user population. All 12 provisioned user accounts were added as members of this group, while administrative and service accounts were excluded where appropriate.

- **Group type:** Global Security Group
- **DN:** CN=All-Sahbak-Users, DC=sahbak,DC=com
- **Members:** All 12 provisioned user accounts
- **Excluded:** Domain Admin accounts and service accounts
- **Purpose:** Primary security-filtering group for organisation-wide user-targeted GPOs



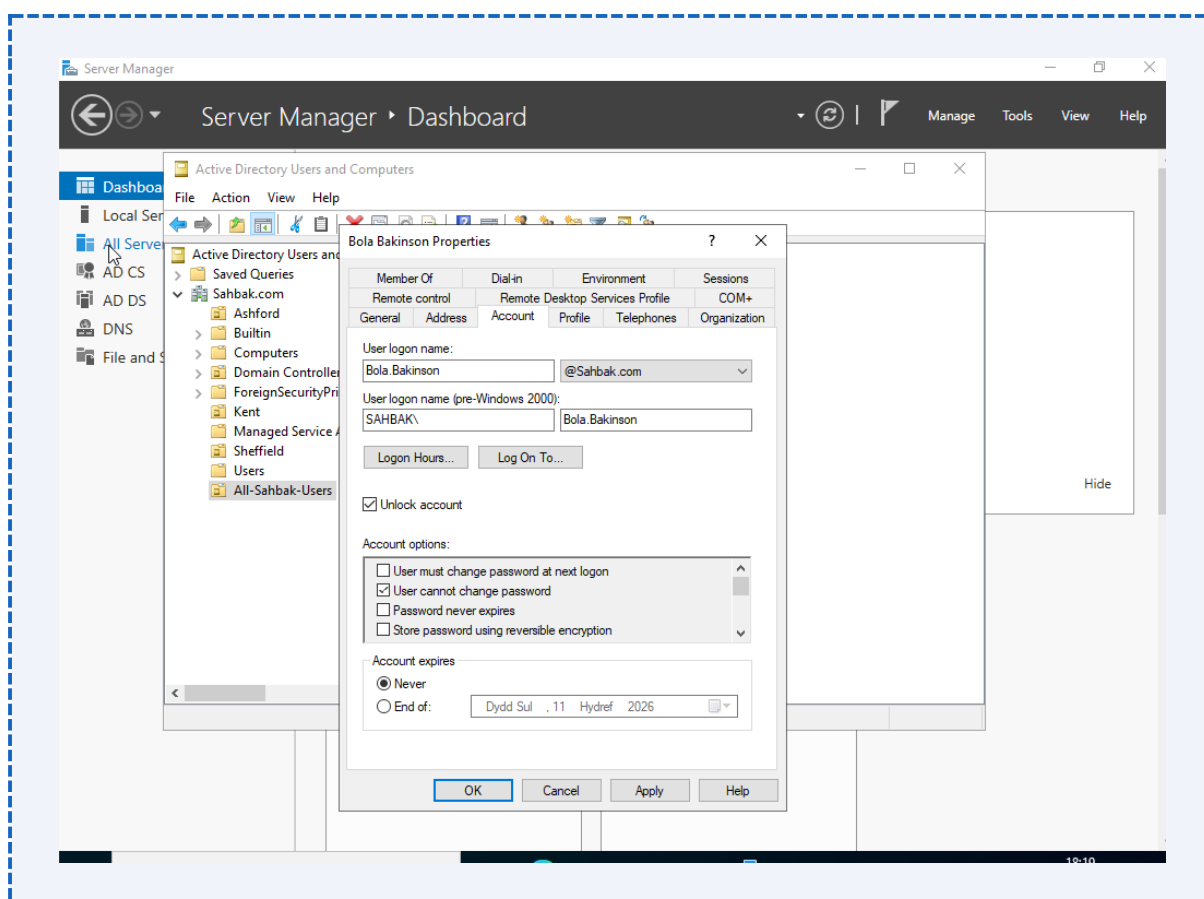
9. Identity Lifecycle Management — Joiner / Mover / Leaver

The Joiner, Mover, and Leaver (JML) framework is the cornerstone of operational IAM governance. It defines the structured processes for managing identity objects across their full lifecycle — from initial provisioning on hire, through role changes, to secure de-provisioning on departure. The following processes were defined and demonstrated within the sanstech.ai AD environment.

9.1 Joiner Process — New Hire Onboarding

When a new employee joins Sahbak, the following AD provisioning sequence is executed:

1. Receive a completed New Starter request via ITSM (e.g., ServiceNow ticket) containing: full name, office location, job title, department, line manager, and start date.
2. Determine the appropriate OU (Ashford, Kent, or Sheffield) based on the employee's office location.
3. Determine the appropriate Security Group based on the employee's department (Human Resources, IT Department, Logistic, Procurement, Audit, or Finance).
4. Create the AD user account in ADUC within the correct OU with the following mandatory attributes: UPN (firstname.lastname@sahbak.com), sAMAccountName, Display Name, Department, Job Title, Manager, and a secure initial password.
5. Add the user account to the appropriate Security Group — access to resources is inherited via group membership (RBAC).
6. Ensure the account is subject to the Password Security Policy GPO and any relevant restricted-access GPOs via security filtering.
7. Notify the line manager and IT provisioning confirmation is complete. Log ticket resolution with the created UPN and account SID.
8. User is prompted to change their password on first logon (or admin sets and communicates a secure temporary password).



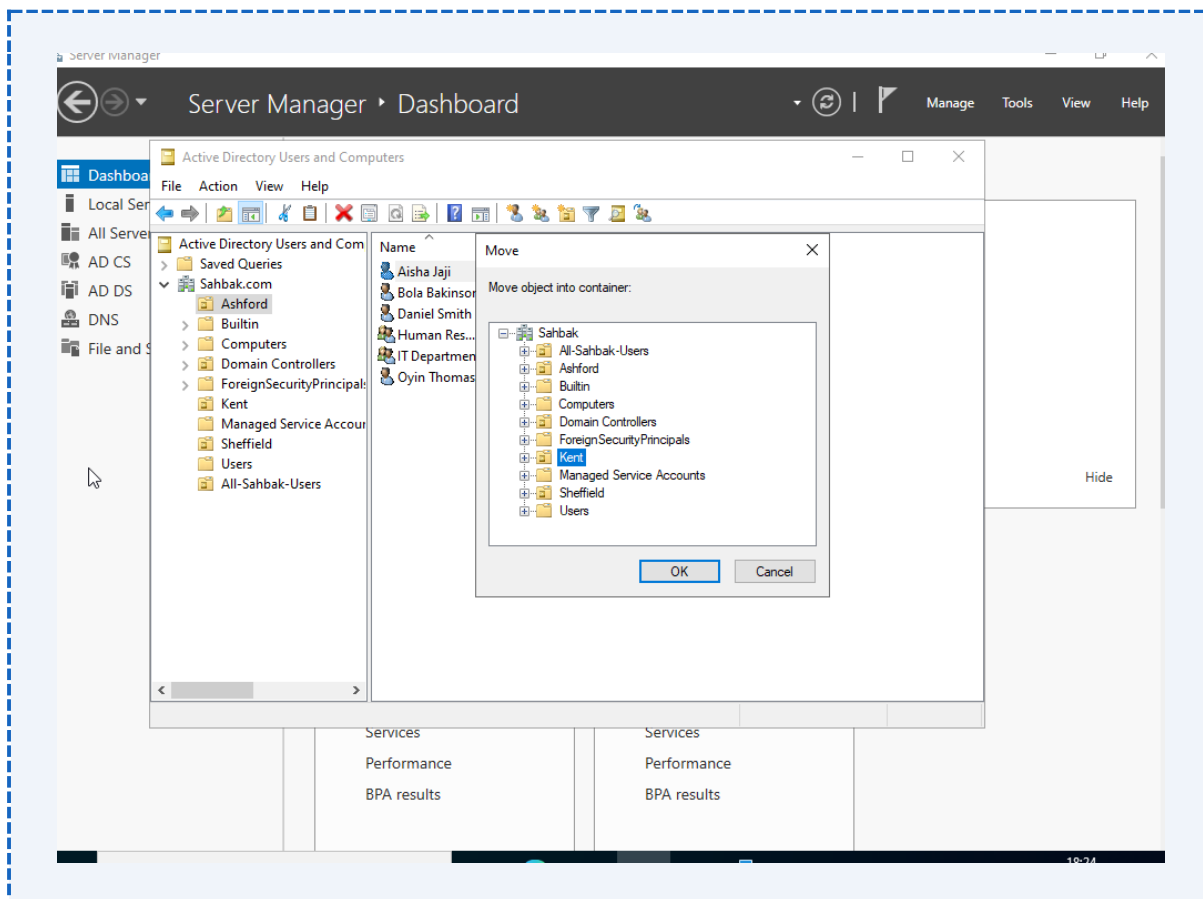
MIM Integration Note

In a Microsoft Identity Manager (MIM) environment, the Joiner process can be automated using the MIM Synchronisation Service and Management Agent connected to an HR source system. MIM can read new-hire records, map identity attributes, and provision Active Directory accounts automatically. The attribute structure used in this project, including UPN, Department, and Manager fields, is designed to align with this type of automated provisioning workflow.

9.2 Mover Process — Internal Role or Location Change

When an employee changes role, department, or office location, the following AD update sequence is executed to ensure access aligns with new responsibilities (preventing privilege accumulation):

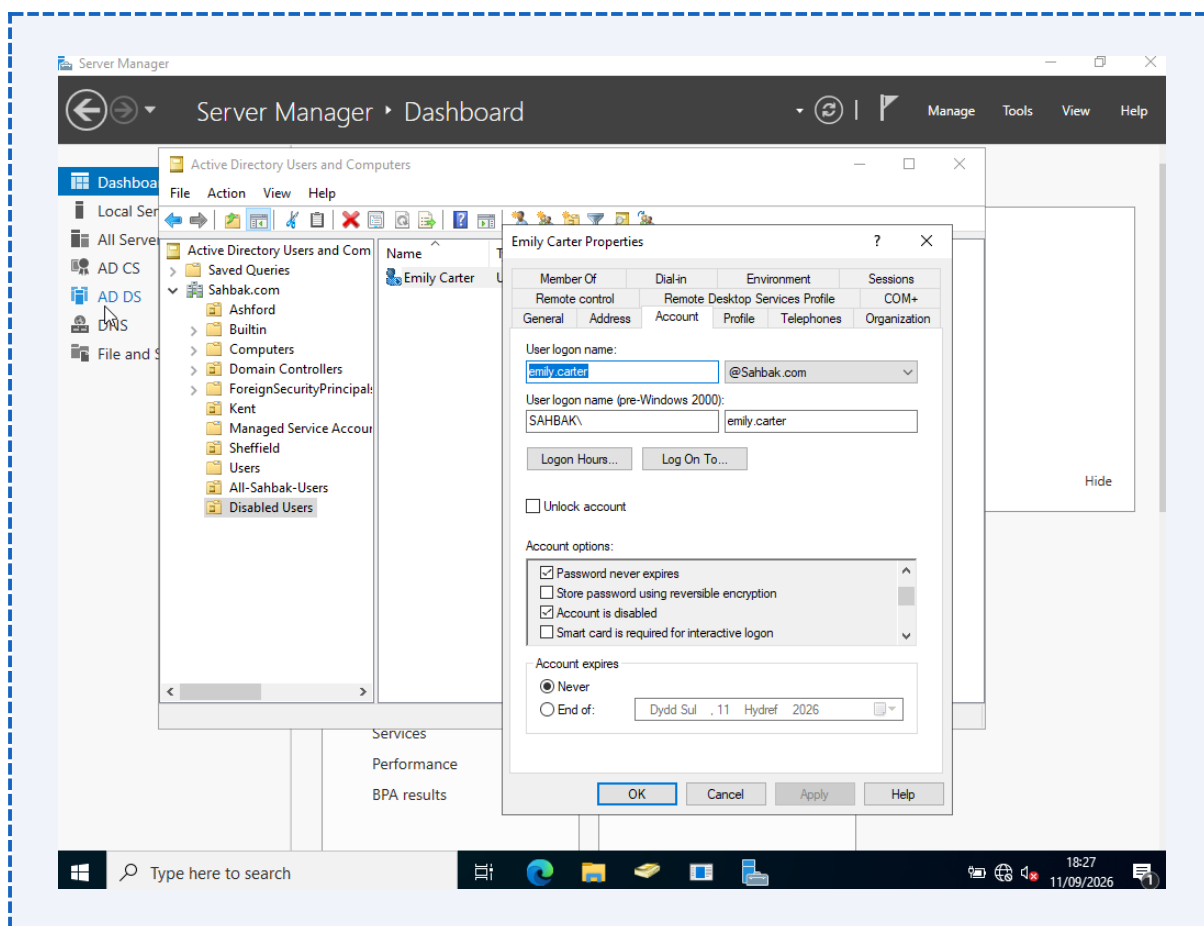
9. Receive an approved Mover request via ITSM, authorised by the employee's new line manager.
10. Move the user account to the appropriate OU if the office location changes, using ADUC or PowerShell.
11. Remove the user from security groups associated with their previous role to revoke access that is no longer required.
12. Add the user to the appropriate security groups for the new department or role.
13. Update the user's AD attributes: Job Title, Department, Manager, and Description fields.
14. Update the UPN only if the user's name changes or another identity naming requirement applies. A department or role change alone does not require a UPN change under the `firstname.lastname@sahbak.com` naming convention.
15. Verify GPO application is correct for the new OU scope using `GPRESULT /R`.
16. Confirm with the new line manager and close the ITSM ticket.



9.3 Leaver Process — Employee Departure

When an employee leaves Sahbak, the following de-provisioning sequence is executed to ensure timely and complete access revocation — the single most critical IAM risk control:

17. Receive a Leaver notification from HR via ITSM, specifying the final working date.
18. On the employee's final day, disable the user account in Active Directory Users and Computers (ADUC) to immediately prevent further sign-in. Reset the account password to a long random value to prevent use of any cached credentials.
19. Remove the user from all Security Groups — this revokes all group-inherited resource access.
20. Move the disabled account to a dedicated Disabled Users OU (e.g., OU=Disabled Users,DC=sahbak,DC=com) to separate it from active objects and exclude it from GPO scope.
21. Terminate any active sessions where possible and ensure the disabled account can no longer authenticate to domain resources.
22. Preserve any required user data in accordance with the organisation's retention policy.
23. Schedule permanent deletion of the AD object after the retention period, documented in the ITSM ticket.



Leaver Risk Control

Prompt account disablement on the last working day is the single most impactful IAM control for reducing insider threat and credential-based attack risk. In this project, the leaver process was designed to complete account disablement within 4 working hours of the final day — exceeding the standard 24-hour SLA typically required by enterprise IAM policies.